ATHENS SPECIAL
EVENTS COLLECTIVE

EXPLORATORY RESEARCH

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OBJECTIVE

The Special Events Collective's goal is to bring 7+ independent events together under one shared voice. The goal is to strengthen Athens' festival culture through funding, branding, sponsorships, shared resources, better data, and stronger community connections while protecting the uniqueness of Athens.

1. **CREATE THE BRAND**
2. **WEBSITE REDESIGN**
3. **DEVELOP SPONSORSHIP OPPORTUNITIES**
4. **STRENGTHEN THE VOICE + PROMOTE**
5. **CREATE A SHARED COMUNITY SPACE**

OUR CLIENTS

Currently, our already work together and share common goals, but there is not yet a formal collective that unites them under one platform. There are three directors that we are communicating with that represent this existing collaboration and are helping shape what a more official Athens event collective could become.



Gene Dixon

Twilight Director

Gene is the founder and events director of Athens Twlight Criterium. He is the founder of Swagger, USA Crits, and helps cities nationwide develop bike races.



Timi Conley

Wild Rumpus Director

Timi is an artist, musician, and founder of the Wild Rumpus Parade. Since launching the event in 2009, he has grown it through sponsorships, grants, partnerships, and community involvement.



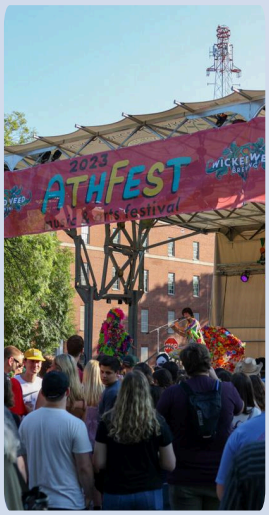
Mary Joyce

AthFest Educates Executive Director

Mary expands access to K–12 music and arts education in Athens-Clarke County through AthFest Educates, overseeing programs, fundraising, grants, and major events.

OUR CLIENTS

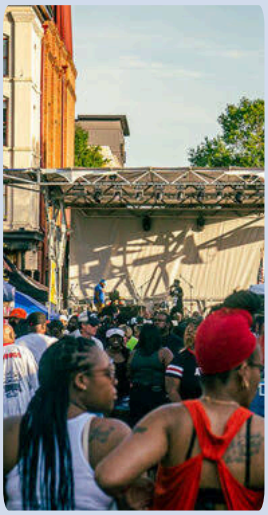
Together, our clients represent...



ATHFEST



TWILIGHT



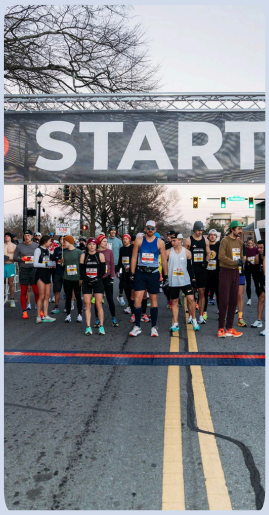
HOT CORNER FESTIVAL



ATHENS FILM FESTIVAL



JOKERJOKER TV



CLASSIC CITY MARATHON



MLK DAY PARADE



LATINFEST



WILD RUMPUS



PRIDE FEST

TARGET AUDIENCE

The target audience includes

- Athens residents
- local businesses
- sponsors
- visitors
- UGA students

One of the biggest challenges is that students are not always as involved in local Athens events as they could be. The Collective can help connect students more closely to the city's culture and encourage them to attend and support events beyond campus. This can be difficult because local events are competing with UGA, which has significantly more resources.

SPONSORS

Current sponsors of these events:

- Creature Comforts Brewing Co.
- DT ATH
- Widespread Panic
- Paloma Park
- Union Fare
- The Hammer Family
- Ruby Sue Graphics
- Greater Athens Properties
- Powerload Electric
- Cheba Hut Toasted Subs
- T.P O'Shea
- Taco Mama
- The Rook & Pawn
- Rabic Hole Studios
- The Adams Family
- Flagpole
- Classic Citiva
- Loving Botanicals CBD
- Brasher Media
- Captive8
- Pat and Neil Priest
- Trappeze Pub
- Joiner and Associates Realators Inc.
- Center for Global and Cultrual Student Engagemtnt UGA
- Metro Atlanta MACC Cycling Club
- The White Line
- Satisfactory Screenpringting and Design
- UGA Grady
- Kidd Fielteau
- The Rock Lobsters
- Specialty Paint and Body
- White Claw
- Miller Lite
- Fleet Feet
- Maepole
- Hotel Indigo
- Jakroo
- Mellow Mushroom
- Montana Grill
- Power 100.1
- Biggum's Bar-b-que
- 960 The Ref
- Ciné
- Thunderfoot Studio
- Leslie Jones Law
- Athens, GA Film Office
- Athens Events
- Agora Vintage
- Flagpole
- Carson Advisory Group
- William Overend
- Country Finanical
- Hotel Abacus
- Live Wire
- Athen Area Chamber of Commerce
- Visit Athens GA
- Terrapin Beer Co.
- Barron's Rental Center
- Chic-Fil-A (Beachwood, Downtown, Barnet Shoals)
- EPTING Catering and Design
- Athens First United Methodist Church

SPONSORS

- Lululemon
- Piedmont Athens Regional
- Foot 26 Ankle
- Pinnacle Bank
- Grand Oak healthcare
- Summer Plumbing
- Oconee Recovery bar
- Earth Fare
- Watertight Roofing
- Athens Running Co.
- Publica Coffee Roasters
- Wag CPA
- Athens Counseling Center
- Athens Road Runners
- Journey Juice
- Elwood & Goetz
- Milestone Construction
- Tucker Capital Group
- University Tire
- Brand & Britt Insurance Agency
- Partner Technology
- Cross Fit Liberate
- Cutters Pub
- Athens Retina Center
- Smoothie King
- Lady Bird
- The Place
- Jackson Electrical Membership Corporation
- ECO Products
- Oconee State Bank
- Joiner & Associates Realtors
- RAIN
- Resource Partners
- American Pride Bank
- Taqueria la Parrilla
- Independent Baking Co.
- Melissa & Jarrett
- Bar Bruno
- Bella Salon
- PSI
- Norris Injury Law
- Chaparral Salon
- DAP Athens
- Grail Bra Specialists
- Pink Goblin Tattoo & Piercing
- R&R Flowers
- Sew Gloria Designs
- Unitarian Universalist Fellowship of Athens
- Ted’s Most Best
- Cafe Racer
- El Paso
- Clocked!
- Aubrey Entertainment
- El Paso
- ACC Solid Waste Department
- Asap Glenn Company
- Law Offices Eric K. Krastle
- DePalmas
- Flicker
- Brasher Media
- Sister Louisa’s Church
- NPS Athens
- Vansplainer
- Bernstein Funeral Home and Cremation Services
- Athens Orthopedic Clinic
- St. Mary’s
- AKO Signs
- The Red & Black
- Lou Sobh

COMPARABLE COLLECTIVE

Austin, TX is a great example and inspiration of a community united through events and festivals. The city of Austin's office of ACME (arts, culture, music, and entertainment) is a hub for the cities cultural initiatives. The ACME launched "The Creative Reset" in May 2025, which is a year long initiative aimed to celebrate Austin's artists, musicians, entertainment venues, and cultural institutions. Multiple departments came together to create ACME. Their goal is to reimagine how Austin invests in their arts, cultural, music, and heritage. To achieve this, they review years of feedback, host focus groups, and conduct surveys to get insights on what is working or what needs improvement.

COMPARABLE COLLECTIVE

Phase I: ACME Funding Programs

The first phase focuses on improving how Austin supports its creative community through funding. ACME is reviewing programs to make them more accessible and transparent for the community.

Phase II: ACME Cultural Centers and Facilities

The second phase focuses on Austin's city-owned arts and cultural spaces. ACME is gathering feedback through surveys and community listening sessions to understand how these spaces can better serve artists, organizations, and residents in the future.

SOURCES

https://groundbridge.com/bios/gene-dixon/
https://www.austintexas.gov/arts-culture
https://www.austintexas.gov/arts-culture/creative-reset
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https://flagpole.com/topstory/2023/06/21/flagpoles-guide-to-the-25th-annual-athfest-music-arts-festival/
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